Prepare the Way - Advent Week 1

Prepare the Way for God to Come

Isaiah 64:1–9

Theme: Longing for God

Main Idea: Sometimes preparing the way begins simply by admitting how desperately we need God.

Isaiah's prayer is raw and honest: *"O that you would tear open the heavens and come down!"* The people are longing for God to intervene in a world that feels broken and distant from him.

Possible sermon points:

- We prepare the way by acknowledging our need.
- We can bring our honest questions and disappointments to God.
- Even when we feel far from God, we belong to the God who is shaping us.

Advent emphasis: Hope

Key phrase:

"Prepare the way by making room for our longing for God."

Introduction:

Imagine waking up one morning and discovering that God was coming to your house today.

Not someday. Not eventually. Today.

What would you do?

You'd probably start preparing. You'd straighten things up. You'd make room. You'd get rid of the things you wouldn't want God to see. You might even make a list:

Clean the house.
Prepare a meal.
Make room at the table.
Get everything ready.

Because when someone important is coming, we prepare the way.

That is part of what Advent is about. We light candles. We sing songs. We decorate. We tell the story again. We prepare our hearts for Christmas.

But Isaiah gives us a different kind of Advent preparation.

Isaiah isn't calmly saying, "Christmas is coming. Let's get ready."
Isaiah is crying out, "God, where are you? Come down! Tear open the heavens and come!"

This is the prayer of people who are tired of waiting. They have seen devastation. They have experienced silence. They know what it feels like when God seems distant.

And so Isaiah doesn't ask God to send a sign.

He asks God to show up.

"O that you would tear open the heavens and come down…"

It is almost as if Isaiah is saying, "God, we don't need another reminder that you're out there. We need you to come here."

And perhaps that is one of the most honest prayers we can pray in Advent.

Because sometimes we come to Christmas carrying joy. But sometimes we come carrying disappointment, grief, fear, loneliness, or questions we cannot answer.

And Isaiah reminds us that Advent is not pretending everything is fine while we wait for Christmas. Advent is daring to cry out, "God, come."

So today, as we begin this journey of Prepare the Way, Isaiah invites us to prepare more than decorations, schedules, and Christmas celebrations.

He invites us to prepare a way for God to come into the places of our lives where we desperately need Him.

Because the question of Advent is not simply, "Are you ready for Christmas?"

The deeper question is: "Are you ready for God to come?"

Basic Outline:

1. Cry Out for God to Come — vv. 1–4

- "O that you would tear open the heavens and come down…"

- Isaiah begins with a bold prayer: "God, come!"

- He remembers what God has done in the past and longs to see God act again.

- Advent teaches us that it is okay to admit: "God, I need You here."

- Sometimes the first step in preparing the way is simply recognizing our longing for God.

Advent question: Where in my life am I longing for God to come near?

2. Come Honestly Before God — vv. 5–7

- "We have all become like one who is unclean…"

- Isaiah doesn't pretend that everything is fine.

- He acknowledges the people's sin, failures, and distance from God.

- Preparing the way means clearing away the things that keep us from God.

- Advent is an opportunity for confession, repentance, and spiritual honesty.

Advent question: What needs to be cleared away in my life so I can make room for God?

3. Remember Who God Is — vv. 8–9

- “Yet, O LORD, you are our Father; we are the clay, and you are our potter…”

- Isaiah moves from confession to relationship.

- Even when Israel has failed, God is still Father.

- We are still the clay in the hands of the Potter.

- Advent reminds us that our hope isn't based on our ability to get everything right—it is based on who God is.

Advent question: Am I trusting God's character even when I cannot see what God is doing?

Conclusion: Make Room for God

Preparing the way for God doesn't mean making our lives perfect before God arrives.

It means:

Cry out: “God, come.”
Clear the way: “God, change me.”
Trust the Potter: “God, shape me.”

And then Advent gives us the promise Isaiah was longing for:

God does come.

The God who seemed distant comes near.
The God we cannot reach reaches toward us.
The God Isaiah asks to “tear open the heavens” ultimately comes to earth in Jesus.

Advent is the season when we prepare the way—not for an idea, not merely for a holiday, but for God to come near.